



△ Front view of the crown

Crown of Charlemagne

The Crown of Charlemagne is more than a jeweled medieval masterpiece – between the 10th and 19th centuries,

it symbolized the might of the Holy Roman Empire, a vast European state with Germany at its heart. Later, the crown became such a powerful icon that the dictator Adolf Hitler used it in his campaign to create a new German-led empire in Europe in the 1930s.

Also called the Imperial Crown, or Crown of the Holy Roman Empire, it is named in honour of the first Holy Roman Emperor, Charlemagne I (Charles the Great), king of the Germanic Frankish tribes (c.747–814 CE). Although

it is widely referred to as the Crown of Charlemagne, the surviving crown was probably made for the coronation of

Otto the Great (912–73 CE), while

it is thought that Charlemagne himself wore a simpler version for his coronation in 800 CE.

Charlemagne was successful in conquering and unifying much of Western Europe and, after helping to put down a rebellion against Pope Leo III, was crowned Holy Roman Emperor by the grateful pope.



Austrian 100-Euro coin depicting the Crown of Charlemagne

The tradition of imperial rule continued until 1806, when the last Holy Roman Emperor, Franz II, dismantled the empire after military defeat by Napoleon. While Napoleon marched on Franz's base of Nuremberg, Franz moved the crown to Vienna for safekeeping.

Now preserved in the national treasury in the Hofburg Palace in Vienna as part of the Austrian crown jewels – where it is still on public display to visitors – the Crown of Charlemagne is octagonal and is made from eight hinged panels of 22-karat gold. The panels are set with a dazzling range of 144 precious gems, including sapphires, emeralds, amethysts, and more than 100 natural pearls. Typical of Byzantine jewellery, the stones are rough cut, because faceting techniques had not yet been developed. Four of its panels feature scenes from the Bible depicted in *cloisonné* enamel (a form of painting laced with silver or gold wire), a technique that was also characteristic of the Byzantine era.



Coronation of Charlemagne by Pope Leo III in 800, shown in the *Grandes Chroniques de France* (1375–79) featuring an earlier version of the crown

Key dates

800 CE–1945

